

What works on posts — and what doesn't

Evidence from 16 accounts' posts, harvested 2026-09-21

Method: for each account we pulled three slices straight from X search — their all-time top posts (`min_faves:1000`), recent winners (`min_faves:30` , last five weeks), and their ordinary feed as the baseline. 410 posts total, 316 with a reliable baseline. Lift = post likes ÷ that account's median. Accounts span anime news, manga, gaming, deals, AI, and pure-personality meme accounts.

1. The headline findings

1. Short beats long, decisively. Posts of ≤ 12 words carried a median lift of **2.0x** their account's baseline; posts of 25+ words sat at **0.99x**. The top of every single account in the sample is dominated by lines you can read in one breath.

2. Media is table stakes, not a bonus. 184 of 316 baseline-comparable posts carried an image or clip; nearly every top post in the sample has a visual. The interesting part: media alone doesn't create lift (**+0.28**) — it's the price of admission. What you *write over the visual* is the multiplier.

3. The winning format is: visual + short, specific, human line. Not a description of the visual — a reaction to it.

- @historyinmemes, 529,000 likes: *"Michael Jackson realizing they take pictures every time he moves"* (clip + one-line reaction)
- @historyinmemes, 369,000 likes: *"I grew up watching cartoons like this, so don't ask me to be normal"*
- @Okami13_, 45,000 likes: *"Death Stranding 2 has the fastest loading time I've EVER seen in a video game. Don't blink or you'll miss it"*
- @Okami13_, 43,000 likes: *"This modder managed to add Malenia from Elden Ring to Sekiro and she actually fits perfectly."*
- @Wario64, 15,000 likes: *"same"* — on a sale post. Fifteen thousand likes for one word, because it was the exact thing everyone was thinking.

4. Drama and stakes beat announcements. @HazzadorGamin's best posts are conflict: Kojima/Xbox exclusivity drama (**9.5x** baseline), PlayStation "selling games in parts for \$50 each" (**5.6x**). @AIR_News01's best anime posts are reveals with visual proof (Burn the Witch visual, 14k; Tower of God announcement, 13k).

5. The flop pattern is exactly one thing: news relay with no take. - @WSJ_manga, 367 likes (vs 18,000 for their top): *"Demon Slayer: Infinity Castle Part 2 could potentially premiere*

internationally..." - @WSJ_manga, 597 likes: "*BLEACH TV Anime 'BLEACH FES.'*" PV. The event will commemorate the finale..." - @Wario64, 27 likes: "*What Remains of Edith Finch (Steam)* is \$4.09 on Fanatical" (pure link) - @Okami13_, ~660 likes: review-score roundups ("10 - Noisy Pixel, 10 - Digital Spy, 9 - GamingBible...")

Same account, same audience, same day-scale — the difference between 18,000 and 367 likes is *whether the line had a person in it.*

2. Case notes, account by account

@historyinmemes (baseline 132,100) — the extreme version of the pattern. Every top post: historic clip + a caption that's a personal reaction or a joke about the reaction. Every flop: quotes and aphorisms ("*The life you seek is hidden inside the discipline you avoid*" — 1,200 likes vs 529,000 for the MJ clip). **Rule: the visual carries the emotion, the caption carries the personality.**

@Okami13_ (baseline ~9,750) — gaming news with a hype voice. Winners are *specific and sensory* ("fastest loading time I've EVER seen", "Naval combat looks INSANE"). Flops are listy and administrative (trademark filings, review score aggregation). **Rule: specificity reads as authority; aggregation reads as a wiki.**

@HazzadorGamin (baseline 384) — small account, best-case study. Their 9.5x post is industry drama; their flops are the same Kojima story told flatly ("Kojima says partnership with Xbox goes beyond games..." — 264 likes). Same story, two framings, 14x apart.

@MangaMoguraRE (baseline 5,600) — anime announcements *with the visual attached* (trailer still, key art). Top: 65k for a yaoi webtoon adaptation announcement with art. Flops: 2027 trailers for shows nobody has heard of yet (1,365). **Rule: announcement power = existing fandom × visual quality. Big fandom + strong key art = banger.**

@Wario64 (baseline ~1,044) — the purest demonstration that *voice beats information*. "same" (15k), "State of Japan has ended. I stopped watching because both presentations were too long together" (14k) vs. twenty-odd link posts at 27–155 likes. Same account. The information was identical; the personality was the product.

@Genki_JPN (baseline 595) — cautionary note on repetition: their top post (FF7 Revelation auto-level news, 2,536) and their near-identical follow-up four slots later (139 likes) — the second telling of the same story died. **Rule: never re-post the same fact in the same voice; if you must revisit, change the angle entirely.**

@dril (baseline 31,000) — text-only can win, but only when the joke *is* the format (absurdist fiction, 120k+). Not a transferable model for a media account; it's the exception that proves personality is the whole game.

@TheTuringPost (baseline 1,207) — utility posts ("A free book for you! Fundamentals of Data Visualization", 2,306) beat commentary posts ("Gemini hacked its way out of the sandbox", 9 likes). In AI-content land, *giveaways of genuine value* outperform takes about models.

@minchoi / @rowancheung (AI lane) — winners are demo-driven: "Kling AI is wild. Memes and arts are coming to life" (49k), "We are cooked. Nothing is real anymore" (25k), "Holy smokes... how is this AI? Seedance 2.0 is wild" (18k). The formula: *new model + jaw-drop claim + visual proof*.

@nihilist_arbys, @sugoiLITE, @AIR_News01 — smaller/leak accounts confirm the same: leak/visual + minimal caption works; commentary threads don't.

3. What this means for @panther_twt

Our own drafts failed the exact test this research defines. Compare:

- **Reporter (flop pattern):** *"150 games already verified for the steam frame and reviewers still cannot agree if it is a console or a science project"* — informative, no person in it.
- **Human (win pattern):** *"steam deck 2 is real and supports ue5. my deck aged five years in one headline"* — same fact, but the line has an owner.

The rules this data gives us:

1. **Every post needs a take, not a fact.** If the line would survive being read by a press release generator, kill it. The fact is the setup; the reaction is the post.
2. **≤12 words, ideally one sentence.** Two short sentences max. The 25+ word posts in this sample sat below baseline.
3. **Image on 100% of posts** — it's already our habit (20/20 drafts), keep it. But never let the image do the work alone; the caption must add the person.
4. **Drama > announcement > description.** When choosing between two trends, pick the one with stakes, conflict, or a price tag. "PlayStation charging \$80" beats "PlayStation announces".
5. **Specific > general.** Numbers, names, first-person claims ("the fastest I've EVER seen", "my deck"). Specificity reads as authority and invites replies.
6. **Never repeat a story in the same voice.** Second telling dies (Genki_JPN 2,536 → 139). Rotate angle or skip.
7. **Open loops work for questions, but questions alone don't.** Our data: questions sat at 0.96x — roughly neutral. The replies-under-a-reaction pattern (someone reacting, then asking) is stronger than a bare question.
8. **The "same" test.** If the whole take can be expressed as "same" — i.e., it's the thing the entire fandom is thinking — that's the post. Wario64's 15k one-worder is the north star for in-crowd relatability.

Lane-specific quick sheet: - **Anime:** key art/trailer still + one-line personal reaction; fandom-size beats novelty (announcements for known properties outperform new IP). - **Gaming:** gameplay clip/still + specific claim (loading, fps, mod). Pricing/console drama is the single strongest sub-lane (5–9x baselines). - **AI/tech:** demo visual + jaw-drop claim; utility giveaways (free resources) over model commentary.

4. Caveats (read before betting the farm)

- Sample is search-derived: top posts are pre-selected for engagement, so the *top* lists are reliable but the baseline comparison is the load-bearing part. 410 posts across 16 accounts is enough for directional rules, not statistical law.
- Like counts are snapshots taken during harvest (2026-09-21) and keep growing; a post's number here is a floor, not a final. One account (@minchoi) shows different snapshots between passes.
- Baselines for @Okami13_, @WSJ_manga, @Wario64, @minchoi, @sugoiLITE are approximations (their live-feed pass returned few posts) — their *tops* are exact, their lift ratios are indicative.
- @animecorner_ac was excluded: 26% handle match, meaning the search returned mostly other accounts' posts.
- One data quality note: X search throttled us twice mid-harvest; those runs were re-done. @AniNews and @GenshinUpdate returned too few posts to include in the baseline comparison.

Raw data: `research/post-patterns/raw/*.json` · analysis: `analysis.json` · harvested 2026-09-21.